# CALDAS DA RAINHA — READY FOR INVESTMENT

## INVESTOR GUIDE



# CALDAS DA RAINHA — AT A GLANCE

**58,983 residents (2025; +11.6% since 2021)**

**8,348 companies (2024)**

**€1.86 billion in business turnover (2023)**

**56 minutes to Lisbon; 53 minutes to Lisbon Airport**

**≈400 people at TEKEVER's engineering centre**

**1,600 art and design students (ESAD.CR)**

**116,000 tonnes of Pera Rocha do Oeste (2025)**

**2026 European Capital of Small Retail**



Image: Postais_V3.pdf, p. 1 — city centre (project material; cropped).

# TIME TO INVEST —

## WHY CALDAS DA RAINHA — A CITY IN TRANSFORMATION

In a rapidly changing global economy, cities must be able to adapt to uncertainty, build resilience and embrace change without losing their identity. Success depends on turning that adaptability into tangible results.

Supply chains are moving closer to Europe, while energy and digital technologies are reshaping industry. Skilled professionals increasingly seek places where they can enjoy a high quality of life while building rewarding careers. Caldas da Rainha is responding to these changes. A defence technology company established here has become a unicorn. German industrial investors recognised the quality of our technical expertise years ago. And the European Commission named our city the 2026 European Capital of Small Retail.

The city is building on this momentum. It is well placed to develop an aeronautics cluster, strengthen its role as a hub for social impact and further expand its distinctive creative industries, with industry remaining at the heart of its economy. To support this ambition, the municipality is developing a professional system for attracting and facilitating investment.

## OUR CHALLENGE

To attract outstanding companies and talent, positioning the municipality as a driving force for national and international development.

## WHY THIS IS YOUR OPPORTUNITY

As an investor, you need a location where setting up and growing a business is straightforward, efficient and transparent. The municipality is committed to providing exactly that environment.

- Direct access to decision-makers;

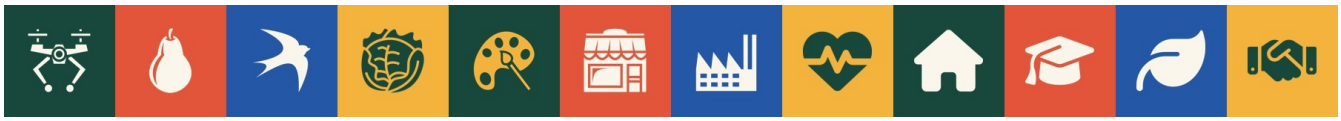
- Established business and industrial areas, with significantly more land becoming available;

- A distinctive pool of skilled talent;

- Proximity to Lisbon, Portugal’s economic centre and an international technology hub;

- An excellent quality of life, with access to housing, education and healthcare;

- Access to EU investment incentives that can be more attractive than those available in the capital.



## ALIGNED WITH THE EUROPEAN UNION'S REINDUSTRIALISATION STRATEGY

Competitiveness Compass;

Clean Industrial Act;

Industrial Accelerator Act;

SAFE — Security Action for Europe.

## A MUNICIPAL LEADERSHIP TEAM WITH BUSINESS EXPERIENCE

Attracting investment is central to our vision for the municipality. The Mayor and Deputy Mayor are both entrepreneurs who entered public service to help transform Caldas da Rainha. They understand the challenges of running a business and the importance of private initiative. After years of improving municipal procedures, the city is ready to take a more prominent place on the investment map. Our executive team combines practical business experience with a clear understanding of what the municipality needs to succeed.

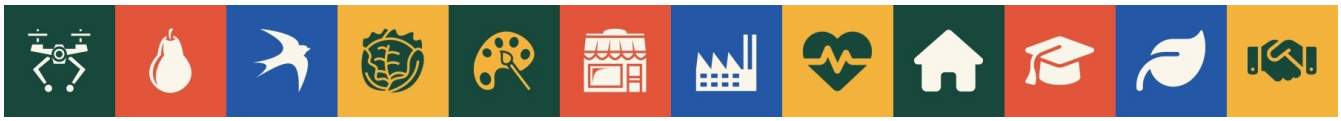
## PARTNERS YOU CAN TRUST

Foreign direct investment in Portugal remains encouraging, and there is broad national agreement on its importance. However, investors still face challenges, including complex administrative procedures and regulations that are not always business-friendly. We understand how important it is for businesses to have reliable partners at both technical and political levels. Partners who act transparently, meet deadlines and are accountable for results.

## A HISTORY OF INNOVATION

Caldas da Rainha was founded on innovation. In the late 15th century, Queen Leonor established a thermal hospital that combined the distinctive qualities of the local waters with a commitment to care for all. Its mission was laid out in a written charter, the Compromisso, with clear rules and objectives. This pioneering initiative helped define the city's character: bold ideas supported by lasting commitments.

In the late 19th century, innovation took a new form. Under the influence of Rafael Bordallo Pinheiro, ceramics challenged conventions and reached new markets. Creativity, humour and social satire were combined with industrial production, establishing Caldas da Rainha as an international reference and creating a network of talent that endures today. Throughout the 20th century, the city developed a diversified economy, with resilient traditional retail in its centre, industries ranging from cutlery to machinery and equipment, and services including logistics and distribution.



# KEY SECTORS — Industry

## WE ARE INDUSTRY

Design, creativity and a distinctive product identity help businesses stand out in global markets. In Caldas da Rainha, this is more than a theory. The Strategic Economic Development Plan (PEDE 2035) brings together industry, the creative sector and innovation in a single cluster. It is one of the municipality's most significant economic clusters, comprising 911 establishments, approximately 3,800 jobs (17.9% of local employment) and €354 million in turnover. Between 2017 and 2022, it outperformed the Oeste regional average in business activity, employment and company growth [1].

Talent underpins this cluster. The municipality has eight higher-education graduates per 1,000 inhabitants, above the national average [2]. ESAD.CR, a school of art and design established in 1990, plays a central role in developing that talent. Within a compact urban area, graduates and entrepreneurs can find spaces to create and work: SILOS – Contentor Criativo, located in a former flour mill since 2010; Prontos. and its Impact Village, offering coworking and incubation; the Centro de Artes; and Teatro da Rainha [3]. Caldas da Rainha has been a UNESCO Creative City of Crafts and Folk Art since 2019.

## An industry driven by creativity

Caldas da Rainha has developed an industrial model built on originality. It combines a strong identity, design, technology and manufacturing expertise. Ceramics is a prime example. Bordallo Pinheiro demonstrates how industrial heritage and contemporary design can reinforce each other, while Molde, Braz Gil Studio and a new generation of studios are following a similar path. The cutlery industry, where family businesses have grown into global brands, shows that this model extends well beyond ceramics. The municipality's skilled workforce has also attracted international engineering, tooling and equipment companies. Supporting this ecosystem is an unusually strong technical training network for a city of this size. CENCAL trains ceramics technicians, while CENFIM specialises in metalworking and automation. Secondary schools also offer vocational courses in IT, robotics, electronics, automation and mechatronics.

## Ready for Industry 5.0

The European Commission has outlined a new vision for manufacturing: Industry 5.0. Automation and digitalisation, central to Industry 4.0, are no longer sufficient on their own. The industry of the future must put people first, operate within environmental limits and be resilient to disruption. Caldas da Rainha has a distinctive set of skills and capabilities to contribute to this model.

## The three pillars of Industry 5.0

Human-centricity: putting people at the heart of production, with technology supporting workers and freeing them from repetitive tasks.

Sustainability: using resources more efficiently, reducing environmental impacts and embracing the circular economy.

Resilience: preparing companies and organisations to withstand supply-chain disruptions, geopolitical instability and extreme weather.

A people-centred industry depends on professionals who combine practical skills with creative thinking, talent Caldas da Rainha has cultivated for generations. But resilient businesses also need resilient infrastructure. In the first half of 2026, for example, the municipality managed a sharp increase in urban waste without disruption to services. This capacity to respond effectively to pressure is an important advantage for investors. The municipality also plans to invest more than €8 million in upgrading wastewater treatment facilities for the next decade. Urban regeneration projects are moving infrastructure networks underground to improve their resilience. New business areas are being designed to balance everyday mobility with freight transport and to benefit from highly connected fibre-optic networks.

For investors, the result is a location combining skilled talent, a strong industrial base, resilient infrastructure and openness to new opportunities.

*Sources: [1] PEDE Caldas da Rainha 2035 – Diagnostic Report (EY-Parthenon, 2025), section 4.3, pp. 47–50. [2] Ibid., section 2.2, pp. 20–21. [3] silos.com.pt; prontos.pt; rpac.pt. Industry 5.0: European Commission, "Industry 5.0 – Towards a sustainable, human-centric and resilient European industry" (2021).*

# KEY SECTORS — Aeronautics

## A unicorn has landed. More are welcome!



Image: municipal postcard collection (VF), p. 1.

Caldas da Rainha was chosen by a leading developer of unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) as the location for its development and production centre. Its strategic Euro-Atlantic position, suitable infrastructure and ability to attract and retain talent make it an ideal setting for growth. The municipality is an active partner in the company's expansion. Current planning and investment are creating opportunities for a wider aeronautics cluster with international reach.

The company is already a major anchor for the region, with a drone pilot training school and facilities dedicated to aircraft engine development. A runway and additional facilities are planned in Caldas da Rainha over the coming years, expanding its capacity for local operations and growth. The municipality is working with the relevant national authorities to identify effective solutions for the area, the company and prospective investors.

The municipality considers aeronautics a strategic priority and aims to contribute to the national strategy for the sector, strengthening its role in an increasingly important international industry.

### IN FOCUS

Caldas da Rainha is home to the engineering centre of TEKEVER, the Portuguese drone manufacturer that became the country's first defence-tech unicorn in 2025. Its unmanned aircraft are designed here before undertaking missions across Europe and beyond.

TEKEVER chose Caldas da Rainha for its skilled workforce, quality of life and location approximately one hour north of Lisbon. Its success demonstrates that a mid-sized Portuguese city can support world-class deep-tech businesses.

The growing network of engineers, suppliers and specialist expertise surrounding TEKEVER creates opportunities for other technology companies seeking to scale from this region.

### KEY FIGURES

**2025 — Portugal's first defence-tech unicorn**

**≈400 — people at TEKEVER's engineering centre**

**≈1 hour — from Lisbon**

# KEY SECTORS — Ceramics Industry

## Innovation Powered by Heritage.



Image: municipal postcard collection (VF), p. 3.

### THE CLUSTER THAT MOULDS THE CITY

Ceramics has shaped Caldas da Rainha for centuries. Today, it forms a complete ecosystem rather than a single industry. Alongside Bordallo Pinheiro, the city's industrial base includes Molde, founded in 1988, which launched its own brand of tableware, decorative pieces and tiles made from locally sourced fine stoneware in 2018 [1]. Braz Gil Studio, a family-owned porcelain manufacturer founded in 1996, produces luxury pieces and reproductions for palaces and museums [2]. Design-led producers such as Duro Ceramics combine handcrafted techniques with contemporary collections for international buyers [4]. They build on the legacy of SECLA, whose studio brought together prominent Portuguese artists during the second half of the 20th century [3].

CENCAL, the ceramics industry's vocational training centre since 1981, trains technicians and operates an accredited ceramics laboratory. ESAD.CR teaches product design specialising in ceramics and glass. A new generation of ceramic artists, including young people and international newcomers, is opening studios, galleries and independent shops [5]. MESTRA, the city's ceramics market, brought together more than 110 ceramicists in 2026 [6]. The Museu de Cerâmica, the Rota Bordaliana and the city's UNESCO Creative City designation, held since 2019, complete this ecosystem. For investors, the city offers suppliers, skilled labour, research and development capabilities, and an active creative market, an ideal environment for new brands, design-led manufacturing and materials innovation.

*Sources: [1] Molde, supplier profile at Formland. [2] Braz Gil Studio, "Our History", brazgil.pt. [3] Associação Portuguesa de Cidades e Vilas de Cerâmica, "Caldas da Rainha". [4] Duro Ceramics, Maison&Objet brand page. [5] CNN Portugal, 15 Jun. 2025. [6] Tinta Fresca, 1 Jun. 2026.*

### IN FOCUS

Since 1884, Bordallo Pinheiro has helped reinvent ceramics in Caldas da Rainha. Rafael Bordallo Pinheiro challenged the conventions of his time through satire, nature-inspired forms and colour.

Today, the company bearing his name, part of the Vista Alegre Group, continues to transform that heritage into new creations. By reissuing historic moulds, working with contemporary artists and designers, and reaching markets across Europe, the United States and Japan, Bordallo Pinheiro connects tradition with innovation.

It remains a living platform for innovation, supported by skilled craftspeople, the CENCAL ceramics training centre and the nearby design school.

### KEY FIGURES

**1884 — Bordallo Pinheiro**

**Europe · US · Japan — international markets**

**CENCAL + ESAD.CR — training + design ecosystem**

# KEY SECTORS — Cutlery Industry

## Sharp skills. Global reach.



Image: municipal postcard collection (VF), p. 5.

Cutlery is one of Caldas da Rainha's lesser-known export success stories. IVO Cutelarias began in the 1940s, when a craftsman sold razors from his bicycle.

Today, the family-owned company, based in Santa Catarina, produces around five million knives a year and exports almost all of them to more than 90 countries.

Its success reflects one of the region's strengths: precision metalworking expertise developed over generations and supported by training at CENFIM.

Here, family businesses have transformed traditional craftsmanship into globally recognised industrial brands. Suppliers, toolmakers and new entrants can benefit from an established supply chain and an experienced workforce.

### KEY FIGURES

**≈5 million — knives produced per year**

**90+ countries — export markets**

**1940s — origins of IVO Cutelarias**

### IN FOCUS

CALDAS CUT https://www.caldascut.com/about-event.html

CALDAS CUT marks an important opportunity to strengthen international partnerships and encourage the exchange of technical and artistic expertise. It also promotes the Made in Portugal label as a symbol of precision, durability and design in global markets.

Cutlery is a strategic sector for the Portuguese economy. With annual exports of around €48.6 million, Portugal is a major European supplier to demanding markets including Germany, France and Canada. The Oeste region, particularly Caldas da Rainha and Alcobaça, is at the heart of the industry, accounting for more than 40% of national production.

# KEY SECTORS — Retail

## *Where the street is the marketplace.*

In Portugal, a city whose streets are full of people is a city full of life. In Caldas da Rainha, streets connect communities and public squares serve as shared gathering places, a natural home for independent shops. Retail and services are major drivers of the local economy, accounting for 4,498 establishments (55.9% of the total), approximately €1.25 billion in turnover (63.9%) and 54.9% of local employment [1]. In recognition of this vibrant commercial environment, the European Commission named Caldas da Rainha the 2026 European Capital of Small Retail in the Vibrant City category, selecting it from 28 cities across 13 countries. This distinction complements the city's UNESCO Creative City status, held since 2019.

### RETAIL 5.0 · A Caldas da Rainha model

High-street retail does not compete with online shopping by copying it. It succeeds by offering what digital channels cannot provide on their own, while using technology to improve efficiency. Retail 5.0 puts technology at the service of people: digital tools enhance personal relationships rather than replace them. Caldas da Rainha is developing a new generation of hybrid retail built on three pillars.

People. Personal relationships are the greatest strength of local retail. Caldas da Rainha is investing in welcoming, personalised and increasingly professional service that understands customers, offers expert advice and creates experiences no online platform can replicate.

Digital. Behind the counter, operations are evolving through digital processes, pedestrian footfall data to inform opening hours and campaigns, and a multilingual online marketplace connecting local shops with customers worldwide.

Logistics. Customers can shop in person and receive their purchases at home, or order online and collect them in the city centre. Smart lockers and delivery services connect physical shops with digital customers while encouraging visits to the high street.

## From "Retail 4.0" to Retail 5.0

In Retail 4.0 (2018), Philip Kotler and Giuseppe Stigliano describe how digital technology moves beyond a separate sales channel to become part of the entire shopping experience. They identify ten principles for retail in this new era:

Be invisible: technology simplifies shopping without being noticed.

Be uniform: the same experience across all channels, physical and digital.

Be a destination: the shop has to give people reasons to go there.

Be loyal: build lasting relationships of trust.

Be close: know the customer and personalise.

Be a curator: select and advise, don't just sell.

Be human: the personal relationship remains decisive.

Be inexhaustible: surprise and renew the offer.

Be exponential: use data and platforms to grow.

Be brave: take risks and innovate.

Caldas da Rainha is taking this concept further. Retail 5.0 combines the digital integration of Retail 4.0 with an additional dimension: the city itself. Participatory governance, urban regeneration and retail-focused public policy can make the entire commercial centre a destination, rather than relying on individual shops alone [2].

## Bairro Comercial Caldas da Rainh@

The Bairro Comercial is a key driver of this model. It brings together a digital marketplace, smart lockers, pedestrian footfall sensors and training programmes. Its governance is participatory: the municipality, AIRO, ACCCRO and local retailers work together through the Living Council of Retail & Services and initiatives such as Caldas com Alma and Loja Verde. The neighbourhood is increasingly becoming a testing ground for urban retail policies, where new solutions can be evaluated before wider implementation. Local identity further strengthens the ecosystem, with seven shops recognised by the Comércio com História network, the Rota Bordaliana and major events including MESTRA, Feira dos Frutos, Caldas Nice Jazz, Caldas Late Night and Bazar à Noite.

## Praça da Fruta



Image: municipal postcard collection (VF), p. 7.

Praça da Fruta is the “operating system” of retail in Caldas da Rainha: an open-air market in the central square, brought to life every day by local producers and traders. It is a place where commerce and history come together.

IN FOCUS

# LET US HELP YOU FIND YOUR "SECRET INGREDIENT"

Every successful business has a secret ingredient, and so does every city. In Caldas da Rainha, ours is there for those who know where to look: distinctive buildings ready for new uses, welcoming streets on a human scale and a community that grows with newcomers. The city increasingly welcomes local initiative and participation. This summer, Bazar à Noite, an independent market organised by an association, brought together 56 creators and encouraged nearby shops to stay open later. Projects attract people, people form communities and communities create opportunities for new businesses. Now we are looking for your ingredient: the idea, concept or brand that makes your business unique. Our team can help you find the right space, street and partners to bring it to life. Shall we explore the right formula for your business in Caldas da Rainha?

## CALDAS DE AUTOR - Concepts for Investors

A regional retail hub: Help position Caldas da Rainha as the leading retail destination between Lisbon and Leiria.

Distinctive brands: Build the next brand with national reach, following examples such as Sportino in retail or Fitness Factory in services.

Food and dining: Combine international cuisines with local flavours, beginning at Praça da Fruta.

Independent design: Open galleries and independent shops showcasing work by emerging ESAD.CR designers, following examples such as Laboratório d’estórias.

Urban regeneration: Introduce new retail concepts in distinctive buildings, a future Creative District or neighbourhoods beyond the established commercial centre.

SOURCES

[1] Municipality of Caldas da Rainha, European Capital of Small Retail application (INE data, 2022).

[2] P. Kotler and G. Stigliano, *Retail 4.0. 10 regole per l'era digitale* (2018); Spanish edition: *Retail 4.0. 10 reglas para la era digital* (LID Editorial, 2020); English edition: *Redefining Retail*.

[3] CNN Portugal, 15 Jun. 2025, "Há uma tribo de artistas que está a usar a cerâmica para transformar as Caldas da Rainha".

[4] Gazeta das Caldas, 17 Sep. 2026, "Bazar deu destaque à cerâmica local".

# KEY SECTORS — Tourism

## AN AUTHENTIC AND GROWING DESTINATION

Caldas da Rainha lies at the heart of one of Portugal's strongest tourism regions. Peniche is internationally renowned for surfing, Nazaré for its giant waves, Óbidos for cultural tourism and the Monastery of Alcobaça for its UNESCO World Heritage status. Caldas da Rainha offers attractions of its own: a historic thermal spa tradition, the Óbidos Lagoon, popular with kitesurfers, and Foz do Arelho, where an Atlantic beach meets a sheltered lagoon. The city also offers a year-round cultural programme through venues including the Centro Cultural e de Congressos, Centro de Artes, Museu de Cerâmica and Museu José Malhoa, alongside contemporary creative activity at ESAD.CR and SILOS. The emphasis is on sustainable, distinctive tourism rather than mass tourism.

The figures show the opportunity:

Growing demand: the city recorded 207,225 overnight stays in 2023, up 12.0% from 2017, nearly twice the national growth rate of 6.6% [1].

Demand outpacing supply: accommodation supply increased by 50%, reaching 30 establishments and 1,670 beds, but demand is growing faster. The PEDE recommends expanding accommodation capacity [1].

Potential for higher-value tourism: revenue per available room (RevPAR) stands at €27.6, compared with €40.4 in the Oeste region and €64.8 nationally. With an average stay of 2.0 nights, there is scope for more high-quality, higher-value accommodation [1].

Established specialisation: tourism and the local economy form the municipality's only cluster with a higher concentration of activity than both the Oeste region and Portugal as a whole [1].



Image: municipal postcard collection (14 October), p. 13.

Where to invest: the PEDE identifies four areas [1]:

thermal spa and wellness;

creative tourism linked to ceramics and art;

business and events tourism (MICE);

integrated offers with Óbidos, Nazaré and Peniche.

Strategic alignment: these investment areas reflect the priorities of Turismo Centro de Portugal for 2020–2030, including wellbeing, business tourism and lifestyle [2]. The Centro 2030 framework recognises Caldas da Rainha as a UNESCO Creative City and includes plans to strengthen thermal and slow tourism, as well as establish a Convention Bureau for the Centro region [3].

Investor support: the Escola de Hotelaria e Turismo do Oeste develops skills for the regional tourism sector [2]. Turismo de Portugal offers support programmes, financing options and the potential tax benefits associated with Tourist Utility status [4].

*Sources: [1] PEDE Caldas da Rainha 2035 – Diagnostic Report (EY-Parthenon, 2025), pp. 43–46 and 71–73. [2] Turismo Centro de Portugal, Regional Tourism Development Plan 2020-2030. [3] Turismo Centro de Portugal, Turismo Sustentável Centro 2030 – Strategic Framework (2023). [4] business.turismodeportugal.pt.*



Foz do Arelho · Alexey Komarov · CC BY 4.0 · Wikimedia Commons (cropped).

# KEY SECTORS — Health and Wellbeing

## *A city founded on care.*

Caldas da Rainha was founded on a tradition of care. In the late 15th century, Queen Leonor established a thermal hospital here, one of the oldest institutions of its kind in the world. Today, this heritage is helping shape a new economic sector. In October 2026, the University of Leiria and Oeste opened a health sciences campus in the city, initially offering courses in thermal spa services, wellbeing, cosmetics, healthy nutrition and laboratory sciences. Degree programmes in digital health and biomedical laboratory sciences are awaiting accreditation. Major private healthcare providers and an active social-impact community further strengthen the local ecosystem. Caldas da Rainha welcomes investment in wellbeing, health technology and social innovation.



Image: municipal postcard collection (14 October), p. 11.

# KEY SECTORS — Design

## Design that changes the game.




Image: municipal postcard collection (VF), p. 9.

In Caldas da Rainha, design does more than shape appearances: it changes how businesses operate. Since 1990, ESAD.CR, the School of Art and Design, has trained designers, artists and makers in the city. Its research laboratory, LiDA, worked with a leading glass manufacturer to develop one of the lightest wine bottles on the market. The project received a Red Dot Design: Best of the Best award in 2026. This is an example of design reshaping a product, its supply chain and an industry. Caldas da Rainha has been a UNESCO Creative City of Crafts and Folk Art since 2019. Creative hubs such as SILOS and Prontos. help retain local talent. For investors, the city offers access to designers, prototyping facilities and research partners capable of transforming both products and business processes.

**KEY FIGURES**

**- 1,600 — art and design students (ESAD.CR)**

**- up to 80% recycled glass**

**- more than 30% less glass**

**- 40% lower carbon emissions**

2026 — Red Dot Design – Best of the Best

# RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT

### LIDA - Laboratório de Investigação em Artes e Design | Laboratory in Design and Arts

LiDA, based at the School of Art and Design, received an Excellent rating in an evaluation by the Fundação para a Ciência e a Tecnologia (FCT). It conducts research in design, art and culture.

Its mission is to advance applied research, experimental development and knowledge transfer in support of a more sustainable future. To achieve this, LiDA works with businesses, museums, non-governmental organisations and national and international research institutions that share its objectives.

Sources: LiDA, lida.pt; Universidade de Leiria e Oeste, FCT evaluation results published on 15 April 2025: https://www.ipleiria.pt/fct-atesta-elevada-qualidade-das-unidades-de-investigacao-do-ipleiria/

# TALENT — The City and the University

## *Minds in Action.*



Image: municipal postcard collection (VF), p. 13.

In Caldas da Rainha, ideas do not stay on paper. Prototyping, making and practical problem-solving are embedded in education, from secondary school to university. The city has eight higher-education graduates per 1,000 inhabitants, compared with a national average of seven. ESAD.CR trains designers, artists and makers in well-equipped studios and laboratories, turning creative thinking into practical expertise. In October 2026, a new health sciences campus expanded the city's educational offer. Specialist training centres provide industry with a steady flow of skilled workers: CENCAL for ceramics, CENFIM for metalworking and automation, and the Oeste Tourism School for hospitality. Vocational schools further strengthen the talent pool through courses in software, networks, renewable energy and mechatronics. For investors, this means access to creative, technically skilled professionals who are prepared to solve real-world challenges.

The recently established University of Leiria and Oeste, successor to the Polytechnic Institute of Leiria, has reinforced Caldas da Rainha's position as a university city. Alongside its internationally recognised School of Art and Design, the city now hosts a campus of the university's School of Health.

## SCHOOL OF HEALTH CAMPUS of the University of Leiria and Oeste

In October 2026, the university opened a School of Health campus in Caldas da Rainha, initially welcoming approximately 80 students across four higher professional technical programmes: Aesthetics, Cosmetics and Wellbeing; Thermal Spa and Wellbeing; Forensic and Criminal Laboratory; and Healthy Eating. Two degree programmes — Digital Health and Biomedical Laboratory Sciences — are under review by A3ES and could expand the offer in the coming years. The focus is on wellbeing, care and disease prevention, complementing nursing and health technology programmes in Leiria. For investors, this creates access to technicians trained in thermal spa services, cosmetics, nutrition, laboratory analysis and digital health.

## ESAD CR | School of Art and Design of the University of Leiria and Oeste

ESAD.CR is a teaching and research institution located at Campus 3 in Caldas da Rainha. It has around 1,600 students and more than 130 lecturers. Its four-building campus was designed around studios and workshops. Facilities cover ceramics and glass, wood, metalworking, printmaking and screen printing, photography, audiovisual production, theatre, digital fabrication and 3D prototyping. The school offers eight bachelor's degrees: Fine Arts; Spatial Design; Product Design – Ceramics and Glass; Graphic and Multimedia Design; Industrial Design; Cultural Programming and Production; Sound and Image; and Theatre. It also offers master's degrees in Sound and Image Arts, Fine Arts, Product Design, Graphic Design and Cultural Management, along with higher professional technical programmes in digital prototyping, graphic production, digital media and audiovisual production. ESAD.CR also provides a public cultural programme of exhibitions, talks, artistic residencies and performances.

# TALENT — Community of entrepreneurs and Startups

Caldas da Rainha is home to Startup Oeste, an entrepreneurship programme promoted by AIRO, as well as Prontos. Impact Village, a centre for entrepreneurship and social impact. SILOS provides another creative hub, bringing artists and entrepreneurs together in an environment that encourages collaboration across disciplines. People come to work, create, visit exhibitions and exchange ideas. The region offers a distinctive mix of technology businesses, digital nomads, manufacturing companies and service providers, creating valuable opportunities for companies establishing operations here. For startups and emerging businesses, Caldas da Rainha offers an ecosystem with a distinctive Portuguese character, driven by private and associative initiatives. This approach encourages agility, collaboration and a close connection to the business practices of leading European economies.

## PELICAN VALLEY

The pelican is one of the city's symbols. It appeared in the coat of arms of King João II (1481–1495) and was associated with the charitable values that shaped the foundation of the Thermal Hospital. Traditionally, the pelican is depicted nourishing its young by sacrificing part of itself — a symbol of care and dedication.

Pelican Valley is a bold vision inspired by the city's growing private investment in healthcare, its established social-impact community and new investment in technology. Together, these strengths offer the foundations for a distinctive cluster of innovation and impact.

| OPPORTUNITIES | |
|---|---|
| **Design** | - Product design;<br>- Interface design;<br>- Talent in multimedia areas; |
| **Digital** | - Information technology: together with Óbidos, it is the strongest hub north of Lisbon up to Leiria; |
| **Electronics and automation** | - Presence of anchor companies that ensure talent is available to create new services and partnerships; |
| **Agri-food** | - Presence of companies large enough to generate clusters and bring in new services and technologies; |
| **Tourism** | - Growth potential in the digitalisation of services and a digital upgrade of the destination; |
| **Impact economy** | - Make the most of the training dynamics, the health and care services and the incubation programmes existing in the city to develop the best solutions on the market. |

# SOFTLANDING — Work, Incubate, Accelerate

Incubation programmes, workspaces and support for entrepreneurs

## AIRO https://airo.pt/

AIRO — Associação Empresarial da Região Oeste (Oeste Region Business Association) has represented and supported regional businesses for more than 40 years. Based at Expoeste in Caldas da Rainha, it is a valuable partner for investors setting up or expanding a business. AIRO provides certified, subsidised training for SMEs and operates a business incubator, including acceleration initiatives such as Startup Oeste. It also promotes clean-energy projects for collective self-consumption. Through regular events and initiatives, such as the Entrepreneurship in Schools Competition, AIRO connects new businesses with the Oeste region's networks, talent and opportunities.

## STARTUP OESTE

Startup Oeste is AIRO's regional incubation and acceleration programme, launched in November 2024. It connects municipalities, higher education institutions, business associations and incubators within a shared entrepreneurship ecosystem. The programme offers free acceleration initiatives, consultancy, mentoring and a network of service providers offering preferential terms. It also includes physical incubation and coworking facilities, along with a digital platform designed to attract digital nomads to the region.

## UpCaldas

UpCaldas is an incubation, acceleration and coworking hub developed by AIRO and the Municipality of Caldas da Rainha. Based at Expoeste, it forms part of the Startup Oeste ecosystem. Its first phase opened in November 2025 with 12 coworking places. Officially inaugurated on 12 June 2026, the expanded hub includes an auditorium, 14 private offices, 20 flexible coworking places, training rooms and leisure areas, with round-the-clock access. It serves local entrepreneurs, growing SMEs and remote workers, while also aiming to attract digital nomads to the region.

## PRONTOS https://prontos.pt/

Prontos. offers a community of workspaces, business incubation programmes and consultancy services. Focused on the impact economy, it also contributes to the city's wider development. Its community brings together businesses and professionals from different countries and sectors, including the creative industries, technology, health, wellbeing and educational technology. Networking events, coworking facilities and the centrally located Impact Village help entrepreneurs connect and grow.

Prontos. is an important hub for businesses seeking to grow within a collaborative community, build links with the city and access practical business support.

INCUBA
The INCUBA incubation programme helps individuals and teams develop ideas, projects and businesses through tailored support, practical workshops, skills development, mentoring and a community committed to making a positive difference. It welcomes entrepreneurs, teams and organisations at different stages of development who want to turn their ideas into reality.

SHIFT HAPPENS
Designed for more established entrepreneurs seeking to make a difference, Shift Happens is an acceleration programme that turns innovative ideas into businesses with measurable impact. It provides specialist training, dedicated mentoring, access to a community of entrepreneurs and investors, and practical tools for scaling solutions to major societal challenges.

## SILOS - CONTENTOR CRIATIVO https://silos.com.pt/

SILOS – Contentor Criativo is one of Portugal's pioneering spaces for creative industries. Caldas da Rainha was among the first cities in the country to recognise the value of bringing together art, digital creativity, technology and technical expertise. SILOS welcomes creators, freelancers, startups and companies seeking a dynamic environment alongside emerging talents and businesses challenging conventional models. Its flexible facilities include studios, exhibition areas, event spaces and offices, offering a distinctive setting for creative work and collaboration.

## LAB7 COWORK https://laboratorio7.pt/

A centrally located coworking space in a modern building, offering a growing professional community and flexible facilities for both long-term and occasional work.

# SOFTLANDING — Setting up an Industry

The revision of the Caldas da Rainha Municipal Master Plan will increase the land available for economic activity, including industrial development. Existing business areas have also benefited from significant planning changes, including an increase in the permitted building footprint to 75% of each plot, with the possibility of reaching 85%.

A change in land use is also under way near the city's northern entrance to enable further economic activity. Located beside the A8 motorway, the area benefits from excellent accessibility and visibility, as well as an existing network of businesses and services.

The Municipal Master Plan (Plano Diretor Municipal, or PDM) is a municipal planning instrument that establishes the strategic framework for territorial development, including land classification and permitted uses.

It also provides the basis for other municipal planning instruments, including Urbanisation Plans and Detailed Plans.

Source: Fundação Francisco Manuel dos Santos

Caldas da Rainha aims to provide a clear, well-regulated planning environment that makes business establishment easier. The municipality also welcomes leading operators of business parks and other commercial infrastructure to develop facilities that meet market demand.

# BUSINESS LOCATION AREAS

Four business location areas provide a starting point for site selection: Pinhal da Câmara (approximately 1.38 km²), Casal de Santa Cecília (257,254 m²), São Gregório (111,589 m²) and Santa Catarina (186,948 m²). These are total reference areas, not currently available land. Availability, ownership, permitted uses and utility capacity must be checked plot by plot.

Source: Municipal Strategic Economic Development Plan (PEDE), diagnostic report, p. 75. See the bilingual Asset Map in this dossier for individual profiles and site-selection conditions.

# SOFTLANDING — Infrastructure and Networks

## Energy — a strength of the municipality

Transmission grid (REN). The 400 kV Ferreira do Alentejo–Pegões–Rio Maior line terminates at REN's Rio Maior substation and crosses the municipality of Caldas da Rainha through the parish of Vidais. According to REN, construction is scheduled to begin in the fourth quarter of 2025, with completion expected in October 2027. The project is primarily intended to transmit renewable electricity generated in southern Portugal [1]. For energy-intensive businesses, proximity to an extra-high-voltage network is an advantage, although it does not guarantee available connection capacity.

Distribution grid (E-REDES). E-REDES operates the medium- and low-voltage electricity distribution network. Its Caldas da Rainha facilities opened in 2019 and comprise a building of approximately 6,500 m² employing 77 people [2].

Grid access for major consumers. Decree-Law No. 120/2025 amended the exceptional procedure for allocating electricity connection capacity in designated high-demand areas, including a financial guarantee [3]. Applicable procedures and available capacity must be confirmed with the relevant network operator. The municipality cannot guarantee connection capacity.

## Fibre-optic network — national backbone and local access

National backbone (IP Telecom, part of the Infraestruturas de Portugal group). IP Telecom operates more than 6,780 km of fibre-optic cable nationwide and offers redundant network infrastructure [4]. The modernisation of the Oeste railway includes signalling and telecommunications works [5]. The availability of commercial fibre services for a specific property must be confirmed with operators.

Local access (FTTH). In 2024, Vodafone extended its fibre network to three parishes in the municipality: Carvalhal Benfeito, Salir de Matos and Santa Catarina. The latter includes an industrial area [6]. Coverage and connection terms must be confirmed with the network operators for each site.

Regional context. ANACOM reported that FTTH adoption in Oeste e Vale do Tejo was above the national average in the second quarter of 2025 [7]. Regional adoption figures do not establish coverage at an individual business site.

## What this means for companies with large data volumes or data centres

Strength: proximity to major electricity and railway infrastructure, together with telecommunications networks, can support data-intensive operations. Each project requires confirmation of electricity connection capacity, commercial fibre availability and redundancy at the proposed site.

Opportunity: small and medium-sized regional or edge data centres, disaster-recovery facilities serving businesses in Lisbon, and industries requiring data-intensive processing.

# INFRASTRUCTURE SOURCES

[1] REN, Ferreira do Alentejo–Pegões–Rio Maior 400 kV axis. https://www.ren.pt/en-gb/activity/main-projects/ferreira-do-alentejo-pegoes-rio-maior-axis-at-400kv

[2] E-REDES, New facilities in Caldas da Rainha, 4 November 2019. https://www.e-redes.pt/en/news/2019/11/04/new-facilities-caldas-da-rainha

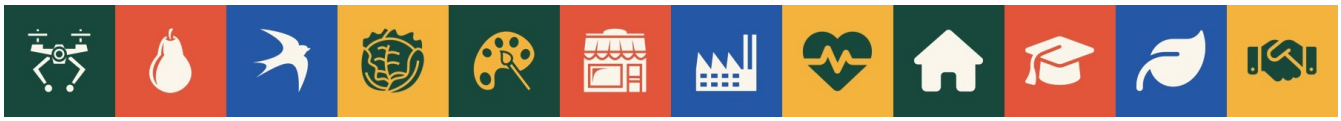
[3] Decree-Law No. 120/2025, 14 November, amending Decree-Law No. 80/2023. https://diariodarepublica.pt/dr/detalhe/decreto-lei/120-2025-946246033

[4] IP Telecom, Infrastructure. https://iptelecom.pt/pt-pt/servicos/infraestruturas

[5] Infraestruturas de Portugal, Oeste railway, Torres Vedras–Caldas da Rainha. https://www.infraestruturasdeportugal.pt/pt-pt/principais-investimentos/linha-do-oeste-troco-torres-vedras-caldas-da-rainha

[6] Gazeta das Caldas, Vodafone fibre expansion, 11 July 2024. https://gazetadascaldas.pt/economia/vodafone-reforcou-rede-de-fibra-otica-nas-caldas-e-alcobaca/

[7] ANACOM, High-speed fixed services, second quarter of 2025, published 18 September 2025. https://anacom.pt/render.jsp?contentId=1816470



# SOFT LANDING — INVESTOR WELCOME AND SUPPORT

We are turning Portugal’s tradition of hospitality into a professional support service for investors. Portugal combines a welcoming culture with strong English-language skills, as well as professionals who speak French, Spanish and other languages. Although a medium-sized European country, Portugal shares a language spoken by around 300 million people worldwide.

Caldas da Rainha is moving beyond a two-tier approach based on access to technical staff and elected officials towards a dedicated, investor-focused service. A specialised office will coordinate investment processes, with a key account manager supporting each project from initial enquiry to completion. This service will work across municipal departments, with clear responsibilities, decision-making authority and measurable performance indicators. Our goal is to make municipal processes responsive to business needs while maintaining transparency and full compliance with the law.



Parque D. Carlos I · Alexey Komarov · CC BY 4.0 · Wikimedia Commons (project photograph, cropped).

# YOUR FIRST 14 DAYS

Proposed investor-support pathway, subject to municipal validation. These are support targets, not licensing deadlines.

D0 | Enquiry and preferred language. Acknowledgement and project reference.

Within 48 hours | First substantive response, named project manager and next step.

D2–D4 | Qualification meeting to agree space, staffing, utilities and timetable.

D5–D7 | Planning and commercial screening with the relevant municipal services.

D8–D10 | Up to three comparable options, or a clear explanation if none are available.

D11–D14 | Site visit or decision meeting, with participants and a written due-diligence plan.

# LET'S DISCUSS YOUR PROJECT

Tell us your activity, space requirements, estimated investment, jobs and timetable. Via Expresso can help identify the next steps and the services relevant to your project.

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## IMAGE CREDITS

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